The Congress party was emphatic that the BJP's over-enthusiastic statements of support towards the US (and Washington's lukewarm response) were unwarranted. Instead, diplomatic energy should have been channeled towards convincing the world community that what was happening in 'Jammu and Kashmir is Pakistan-sponsored, aided, and abetted naked international terrorism', and Islamabad should not be made a stakeholder in this war on terror.[92] Otherwise, another round of arms race will begin in South Asia, as it happened after the Soviet military intervention. Vajpayee's letter to Bush, in this context, was perceived as a sign of weakness, or India being seen as a 'lackey' of US imperialism, as senior SP leader Janeshwar Mishra and the Left parties put it.[93] Given India's tortuous relations with the US, most Indian policymakers advised the government not to trust Washington. The dominant perception in Indian circles was that the US was a fair-weather friend unlike Russia that stood with India in its hour of need (in 1971 and at other times). Other Congress leaders such as Eduardo Faleiro and Kapil Sibal condemned the killing of 'thousands of innocents' in Afghanistan due to the US bombing,[94] and advocated a holistic approach towards dealing with the 'culture of terrorism'.[95] For Sibal, throwing missiles and cluster bombs on a 'wretched' country like Afghanistan that had a life expectancy of 43 years,[96] 23 per cent literacy rate, per capita GDP of less than US$ 700 per year, no access to safe water, sanitation, healthcare, education, and infrastructure, may help [with] catching Osama bin Laden, but was not an adequate answer to dealing with terrorism.[97]

CPM MPs such as Nilotpal Basu, in addition to voicing similar concerns, had an ideological difference with the US. For Indian Communists, the government's offer to use Indian military bases in America's war against Afghanistan would 'seriously undermine national interests'.[98] None of the US actions addressed the root cause of terrorism, which was to overhaul the amoral capitalistic system that contributed towards the growth of religious fundamentalism and sectarianism. Other regional parties such as the SP, the Telugu Desam Party, the Rashtriya Janata Dal, and the Nationalist Congress Party, also held the US partly responsible for the Taliban's growth. Shortsighted support to groups like the Taliban for economic and energy interests, these parties argued, made Afghanistan a safe haven for terrorist outfits. For Basu, it was surprising that the